

Marianna Zhang

she/her

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PROFESSIONAL APPOINTMENTS

Postdoctoral Fellow, Psychology, *New York University* Aug 2024–present
 • Advisors: Marjorie Rhodes & Mark Ho

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Psychology, *Stanford University* 2024
 • Dissertation: Structural thinking and its consequences: a developmental approach. ([dissertation](#))
 • Committee: Ellen M. Markman, Steven O. Roberts, Tobias Gerstenberg, Hyowon Gweon

B.A., Psychology with Honors & Minor in Philosophy, *The University of Chicago* 2018
 • Honors thesis: Perspective-taking in mental imagery of the actions of others. ([thesis](#))
 • Advisors: Daniel Casasanto & Susan Goldin-Meadow
 • Tutorials in Metaphor and Philosophy of Cognitive Science, *St. Catherine's College, Oxford* Autumn 2017

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant, [Experience and Cognition Lab](#) (PI: Dr. Daniel Casasanto), *University of Chicago* 2014–2018
 Summer Intern, [Laboratory for Developmental Studies](#) (PI: Dr. Susan Carey), *Harvard University* Summer 2016
 Summer Intern, [Cognition and Development Lab](#) (PI: Dr. Frank Keil), *Yale University* Summer 2015

PUBLICATIONS

*co-first author, †student advisee

- Zhang, M. Y.**, Ho, M. K., & Rhodes, M. (in prep). Young children fail to adjust inferences about social groups in response to sampling skew.
- Zhang, M. Y.**, Malaviya, M., Leslie, S.-J., Rhodes, M., Ho, M. K. (in prep). Generic language as a source of abstract conceptual knowledge.
- Zhang, M. Y.**, Liu, L.[†], & Markman, E. M. (in prep). How structural thinking shapes children and adults' reasoning about social differences and disparities.
- Zhang, M. Y.**^{*}, Asaba, M.^{*}, & Leonard, J. A. (2026). U.S. Children expect and approve of adults' gender stereotypes. *Communications Psychology*. ([paper](#))
- Zhang, M. Y.**, Sullivan, J. N., Allums, S.[†] & Markman, E. M. (2025). How colorblind and structural messages affect children's reasoning about novel group disparities. *Developmental Science*. ([paper](#))
- Zhang, M. Y.**, Leslie, S.-J., Rhodes, M., Ho, M. K. (2025). Learning about the inductive potential of categories from generic statements. In *Proceedings of the 47th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*. Austin, TX: Cognitive Science Society. ([paper](#))
- Asaba, M., **Zhang, M. Y.** & Leonard, J. A. (2024). Children expect adults to hold gender stereotypes, even when they are not accurate. In *Proceedings of the 46th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*. Austin, TX: Cognitive Science Society. ([article](#))
- Zhang, M. Y.**^{*}, Sullivan, J. N.^{*}, Markman, E. M. & Roberts, S. O. (2023). Children's structural thinking about social inequalities. *Child Development Perspectives*. ([paper](#))

- Zhang, M. Y.,** Liu, L.[†], & Markman, E. M. (2023). Let's talk structure: the positive outcomes of structural thinking. In *Proceedings of the 45th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society* (pp. 1564–1571). Austin, TX: Cognitive Science Society. ([paper](#))
- Chestnut, E. K., **Zhang, M. Y.,** & Markman, E. M. (2021). “Just as good”: Learning gender stereotypes from attempts to counteract them. *Developmental Psychology*, 57(1), 114–125. ([paper](#), [data](#))
- Johnson, S. G. B., **Zhang, M.,** & Keil, F. C. (2016). Decision-making and biases in causal-explanatory reasoning. In *Proceedings of the 38th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society* (pp. 1967–1972). Austin, TX: Cognitive Science Society. ([paper](#))

RESEARCH PRESENTATIONS

- Zhang, M. Y.** Learning social category representations from social structures and language.
Invited talk at Consortium for Interacting Minds (CIM), Dartmouth College. 2027
- Zhang, M. Y.,** Ho, M. K., & Rhodes, M. Children and adults' inferences about social groups in response to sampling skew.
Talk at Society for Philosophy & Psychology (SPP), Johns Hopkins University, Baltimore, MD. 2026
- Zhang, M. Y.,** Leslie, S.-J., Rhodes, M., & Ho, M. K. Learning about the inductive potential of categories from generic statements.
Talk at Computational Psychology preconference, Society for Personality & Social Psychology (SPSP), Chicago, IL. 2025
Talk at Cognitive Science Society, San Francisco, CA. ([slides](#)) 2025
Poster at Society for Philosophy & Psychology, Cornell University, NY. 2025
Poster at Essentialism in the Human Mind conference, University of Massachusetts Amherst, MA. ([poster](#)) 2025
Talk at Diverse Intelligences Summit, Natural & Artificial Minds, Princeton University, NJ. ([poster](#)) 2026
- Zhang, M. Y.,** Sullivan, J. N., Allums, S. & Markman, E. M. How White parents' conversational approaches affect children's reasoning about racial disparities.
Symposium talk at Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD), Minneapolis, MN. 2025
Poster at Origins of the Social Mind preconference, Society for Philosophy & Psychology (SPP), online. 2025
Invited talk at Social and Moral Cognition Lab (PI: Larisa Solomon), Columbia University. 2024
- Zhang, M. Y.** & Markman, E. M. Limitations and future directions in studying structural thinking in young children.
Talk at Cognitive Development Society, Pasadena, CA. ([slides](#)) 2024
- Asaba, M., **Zhang, M. Y.** & Leonard, J. A. Children's representations of others' gender biases.
Symposium talk at Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD), Minneapolis, MN. ([slides](#)) 2025
Poster at Cognitive Science Society, virtual. ([abstract](#)) 2023
Poster at Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD) Biennial Meeting, Salt Lake City, UT. 2023
- Zhang, M. Y.,** Popat, A. K., Santos, M., Mottl, P. R., Bian, L. & Markman, E. M. Language frequently used in best-selling storybooks can thwart their intent to inspire girls.
Poster at Cognitive Development Society (CDS), Madison, WI. ([poster](#)) 2022
- Zhang, M. Y.** & Markman, E. M. Let's talk structure: the positive consequences of structural thinking.
Invited talk at Genericity, Stability, and Structural Interactions workshop, CSU East Bay. 2024
Invited talk at Conceptual Development & Social Cognition Lab (PI: Marjorie Rhodes), New York University. 2023
Poster at Cognitive Science Society, virtual. ([poster](#), [paper](#)) 2023
Talk at Society for Philosophy & Psychology (SPP), Pittsburgh, PA. 2023
Invited talk at Developmental Psychology Colloquium, University of California-Santa Cruz. 2022
Poster at the Society for Personality & Social Psychology (SPSP) conference, San Francisco, CA. ([poster](#)) 2022
(received Graduate Poster Award, Runner-Up)

Talk at Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development (BCCCD), virtual.	2022
Talk at Harvard Women in Psychology Trends in Psychology conference, virtual.	2021
Invited talk at Leonard Learning Lab (PI: Julia Leonard), Yale University.	2021
Poster at Cognitive Science Society, virtual. (abstract , poster)	2021
Talk at Developmental Psychology Area Brownbag, Stanford University. (talk)	2021
Invited talk at Causality in Cognition Lab (PI: Tobias Gerstenberg), Stanford University.	2020
Zhang, M. Y. & Markman, E. M. Essentially blocked: the role of structural factors in blocking essentialism.	
Poster at Cognitive Development Society, Louisville, KY. (poster)	2019
Talk at Developmental Psychology Area Brownbag, Stanford University.	2019
Gijssels, T., Zhang, M. Y. , Lucero, C., Berman, M. G., & Casasanto, D. Understanding language about other people's actions.	
Poster at Cognitive Science Society, Montreal, QC. (abstract)	2019
Zhang, M. Y. , Gijssels, T., & Casasanto, D. Perspective-taking in mental imagery of the actions of others.	
Poster at the University of Chicago Psychology Honors Day Symposium, Chicago, IL. (poster)	2018
Zhang, M. , Haward, P., & Carey, S. Sources of information in the acquisition of principled properties.	
Poster at Harvard University Laboratory for Developmental Studies Summer Internship Poster Day, Cambridge, MA. (poster)	2016

GRANTS & FELLOWSHIPS

AWIS Bridge Grant , Association for Women in Science (\$5,000)	2025
Trailblazer Postdoc Award , Office of the Vice Provost for Research, <i>New York University</i> (\$181,000 for 2 years)	2025–present
SBE Postdoctoral Research Fellowship (SPRF) , Social, Behavioral, and Economic Sciences, <i>National Science Foundation</i> (#2404708, \$160,000 intended for 2 years; administratively terminated)	2024–2025
Graduate Dissertation Fellowship , Clayman Institute for Gender Research, <i>Stanford University</i> (1 year)	2023–2024
Graduate Research Opportunity , School of Humanities & Sciences, <i>Stanford University</i> (\$3,000)	2022
Summer Collaborative Research Fellowship , Stanford Impact Labs, <i>Stanford University</i> (\$4,000)	2022
Research Data Grant , Institute for Research in the Social Sciences, <i>Stanford University</i> (\$1,500)	2021
Norman H. Anderson Research Award , Department of Psychology, <i>Stanford University</i> (\$2,000 x2)	2019, 2023
Regina Casper Stanford Graduate Fellowship in Science & Engineering , <i>Stanford University</i> (3 years)	2018–2021
Dean's Distinguished University Fellowship, <i>Ohio State University</i> (3 years, declined)	2018
Graduate Research Fellowship Program Honorable Mention, <i>National Science Foundation</i>	2018
Earl R. Franklin Research Fellowship , Department of Psychology, <i>The University of Chicago</i>	2017
University Merit Scholarship , <i>The University of Chicago</i>	2014–2018

AWARDS & HONORS

Myra Strober Prize for newsletter writing, Clayman Institute for Gender Research, <i>Stanford University</i>	2024
Albert H. and Barbara R. Hastorf Teaching Award, Department of Psychology, <i>Stanford University</i>	2024
James W. Lyons Award for Service , Dean of Students Office, <i>Stanford University</i>	2023
Graduate Feminist Award , Vice Provost for Graduate Education/Women's Community Center, <i>Stanford Univ.</i>	2022
Graduate Poster Award Runner-Up, <i>Society for Personality and Social Psychology (SPSP)</i>	2022
Phi Beta Kappa, <i>The University of Chicago</i>	2018
Student Leadership Recognition and Access Award , Student Government, <i>The University of Chicago</i>	2016
Dean's List, <i>The University of Chicago</i> (ineligible 2017)	2015, 2016, 2018

TRAVEL & PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Postdoctoral Travel Grant, Arts & Science, <i>New York University</i> (\$700)	2025
Diversity Travel Award, <i>Society for Philosophy & Psychology (SPP)</i>	2023
Diverse Intelligences Summer Institute (DISI), <i>University of St Andrews</i>	Jul 2019
Diversity Travel Award, <i>Cognitive Development Society (CDS)</i>	2019
Concepts in Action: Representation, Learning, and Application Summer School <i>Institute of Cognitive Science, University of Osnabrück</i>	Aug 2018
Norwegian Summer Institute on Language and Mind, <i>University of Oslo</i> (declined)	2018

TEACHING

*online

Guest Lecturer

Gender and Language in Society (ANTHRO 154Q), <i>University of California, Los Angeles</i>	Autumn 2024
Language, Gender, & Sexuality (LINGUIST 156/FEMGEN 156X), <i>Stanford University</i>	Spring 2024

Teaching Assistant (7x), *Stanford University*

Gendered Innovations in Science, Medicine, Engineering, and Environment (HISTORY/FEMGEN 44Q)	Spring 2024
Advanced Research / Honors Program (PSYCH 198)	Autumn 2022
Introduction to Developmental Psychology (PSYCH 60)	Spring 2021*, Summer 2021*
Introduction to Psychology (PSYCH 1)	Autumn 2019, Winter 2020, Spring 2020*

Internship Coordinator, *Stanford University*

CSLI Summer Internship, Center for the Study of Language and Information	2020, 2022
Psych-Summer Research Program, Department of Psychology	2023

Teaching Consultant, *Stanford University*

Mid-Quarter Teaching Consultant, Introduction to Psychology	2021–2024
Graduate Teaching Consultant, Center for Teaching & Learning	2020–2023
Graduate Teaching Consultant Coordinator, Center for Teaching & Learning	2021–2023
Modell, A. & Zhang, M. Y. TA Orientation Any Time: A Self-Paced, Asynchronous Canvas Course.	
Poster (IdeaLab) at Academic Technology Expo (ATXpo), <i>Saint Mary's College</i> .	2023
Talk at TEACH symposium, <i>Stanford University</i> .	2023
Zhang, M. Y. & various co-facilitators. Leading discussions in the humanities & social sciences.	
Invited workshop for TA Orientation, <i>Stanford University</i> .	Winter 2021*, Autumn 2021*, Autumn 2022
Asynchronous course module for TA Orientation Anytime, <i>Stanford University</i> .	2023
Zhang, M. Y. Engaging students in the classroom.	
Invited workshop for Psychology TA Orientation, Psychology, <i>Stanford University</i> .	2022, 2023
Zhang, M. Y. & Guzman, K. Making groups work in class.	
Invited workshop for Teach the Teachers, School of Earth, <i>Stanford University</i> (cancelled).	2022
Zhang, M. Y. & Williams, L. Student engagement online.	
Invited workshop for TA Seminar, Civil and Environmental Engineering, <i>Stanford University</i> .	2020*

MENTORING

Research Mentor (15 students, including †honors thesis students, and *students who took a postgraduate psychology position)

New York University

Shiloh Ye, Neela Rao*, Brenda Chavez-Olguin

Stanford University

Emily Rinehart*, Sachin Allums*, Linda Liu, Kamilah Cole (UC Berkeley), Amy Miyahara†*, Natalie Sarmiento*, Alex Riklin, Mercedes Muñoz* (Boston University), Melissa Santos†*, Aarthi Popat†*, Alanna Sun, Kristine Cho* (Pomona)

Mentor for psychology PhD applicants

NYU [Application Support Group](#) (2025–present), [Project SHORT](#) (2021–present), [Application Statement Feedback Program \(ASFP\)](#) (2021–present), Stanford Psychology [Paths to PhD](#) (2019–2023), Stanford Women’s Community Center [Women in STEM Mentoring](#) (2018–2020)

ACADEMIC SERVICE & LEADERSHIP

*For the public***Science outreach and education** for middle schoolers from underrepresented backgrounds

[Stanford Science Penpals](#) (2018–2020), [The Think Tank](#) educator & events manager (2015–2017; [media coverage](#))

Science funding advocacy & appearances

Zhang, M. Y. (2025). Declaration of Marianna Zhang in support of plaintiff’s motion for preliminary injunction [Exhibit 15]. In *AAPT v. NSF*, No. 1:25-cv-01923-JMC (D.D.C. filed June 23, 2025). ([declaration](#))

Appeared in Myers, S. L. (2025, May 15). Trump Administration Cancels Scores of Grants to Study Online Misinformation. *New York Times*. ([article](#))

Appeared in Gallagher, M. (2025, May 25). Scientists have lost their jobs or grants in US cuts. Foreign universities want to hire them. *AP News*. ([article](#))

Appeared in Greenfieldboyce, N. (2025, May 2). Scientists reel as turmoil roils National Science Foundation [Radio broadcast episode]. In *All Things Considered*. NPR. ([article](#))

NYU Postcards for Science (2025)

Science communication

Zhang, M. Y. (2024). The structural burden of men’s declining social networks. *Gender News*. Clayman Institute for Gender Research, Stanford University. ([article](#))

Zhang, M. Y. (2023). Gender stereotypes contribute to misperceptions of gender norms across the world. *Gender News*. Clayman Institute for Gender Research, Stanford University. ([article](#), received the [Myra Strober Prize](#))

Zhang, M. Y. (2023). The fundamental moral dilemma faced by public experts. *Gender News*. Clayman Institute for Gender Research, Stanford University. ([article](#))

*For the discipline***Ad hoc reviewer**

Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, Developmental Psychology, Child Development, Open Mind, Psychonomic Bulletin & Review, Psychological Science (as co-reviewer), Cognitive Science Society (CogSci), Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development (BCCCD), Society for Philosophy & Psychology (SPP)

Volunteer, Social Justice Bibliography, Cognitive Development Society 2021

For New York University

Organizer, Computational Social Cognition reading group fall 2024

For Stanford University

Diversity Committee, Department of Psychology 2019–2020

Cognitive/Developmental Faculty Search Committee, Department of Psychology 2021–2022

Developmental Area Graduate Admissions, Department of Psychology 2019–2020, 2021–2022

Developmental Area Graduate Interview Weekend, Department of Psychology 2022, 2023

Developmental Brownbag Seminar & Journal club, Department of Psychology 2019–2020

For the University of Chicago

Student Advisory Board, Cognitive Science Program 2017–2018

Faculty Liaison & Peer Mentor, Psi Chi (UC Psych) 2016–2018

REFERENCES

Marjorie Rhodes

Professor of Psychology

New York University

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Mark K. Ho

Assistant Professor of Psychology

New York University

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Ellen M. Markman

IBM Provostial Professor of Psychology

Stanford University

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